

Ridge Racer 7

Every Sony platform has had at least one *Ridge Racer* (RR) title to enjoy, and RR7 is the latest in the line. The franchise has long been one of our favourites—how could you not like a game where most of your responsibility entails drifting your car around corners and winning races? This game offers you raw, unadulterated fun and beautifully unrealistic gameplay—you could be in a car that's moving forwards, but at a 135-degree angle to the road's direction!

Naturally, RR7 has gone HD, and can't help looking good on the PS3. It's also become a tad more difficult. In the previous versions, especially those on the PSP, racking up the drift points for more boost was quite easy; you'll have to drift *really* well for these points now, and if you botch up, your opponents will leave you far behind. The only grouse about this game is that all that drifting can get a little monotonous.

Whether you've played an RR title before or not, this one is highly recommended—no nonsense, all fun.

Rating: 8/10

Lair

Lair isn't part of the launch line-up—it's due for release in the end of July—but it's the first game we'll see that uses SIXAXIS extensively and almost exclusively, and deserves a mention. There'll be battling dragons and



much fire-breathing in a world “torn by conflict and strife.” You use your SIXAXIS controller to control the flight of your dragon as you hunt the skies for enemy dragons, engaging them in fireball-filled dogfights or close-range kick-and-bite attacks. The first mission is training—getting you used to controlling your dragon and learning some basic moves, and even when you consider the fact that we saw some very raw review code, we can see that this is asking for trouble. You have no option but to use the controller's motion sensitivity, so if you're uncomfortable with it like we were, tough. To attack enemy dragons close-range, you need to go near them, jiggle the controller (looking like an over-excited idiot), jiggle some more and finally hit a button combo to kill the enemy dragon rider. We're hoping for a cleaner, tighter control system when the game finally releases. The game has a *Lord Of The Rings*-ish feel—it's set in ancient times, and the

little we saw of the environments suggests the same. Shooting never-ending fireballs at enemy dragons has its own promise of fun. 'Twould be a pity were it to be let down by its controls.

A total of nine games will launch with the PS3, and Milestone Interactive (the ones who are bringing the console and its games to India) has many more lined up for the months that follow.

there's that deadly projectile, the Wiimote—the litres of blood that it's drawn from so many innocents... appalling. We had our go with this satanic device thanks to Yogesh Nagdev, who owns a popular gaming café called Plugin in Vashi, Navi Mumbai. You can, too, if you're ever in the vicinity—it's one of few places (and the only one we know) that will let you game on a Wii.

The Mini-console

The Wii's innards—practically as diminutive as its exterior—are almost embarrassing: where the 360 and PS3 talk teraflops, the Wii's IBM “Broadway” processor and ATI's “Hollywood” R520 GPU place it a wii bit ahead (couldn't resist that one) of the older PS2 and Xbox in terms of raw performance. It's not even truly HD—its 480p resolution will look excellent on a good standard-definition CRT TV, but is quite likely to die on a true HDTV—especially when you look at how beautiful games look with the 360 and PS3. But then, Nintendo isn't banking on wiining (couldn't resist that either) on looks...

All That Hubbub

All Wii-talk is pointless without mentioning the Wiimote—the TV-remote-shaped controller for the Wii (the official name is the Wii remote, but we prefer the corruption). It connects to the Wii via Bluetooth, and detects motion using accelerometers and an infrared sensor bar that you're supposed to place above or below your TV. The controller itself is quite simple—one trigger-like button (B) at the bottom, and a classic NES-like button set on the top. It also features vibration and a little speaker that attempts to give you an added sense of immersion—imaging hitting a baseball and hearing the crack of the shot come from between your hands, and you've got the premise. It sounds a bit tinny, but gets the job done.

Most importantly, the Wiimote comes with a fairly sturdy strap to prevent you from chucking it across the room in excitement—we didn't have any such episodes, but there are people all over the world with bruises and broken furniture that will testify to the need for this strap.

Also part of the package is the Nunchuck, which plugs into the Wiimote, and is quite obviously built for first-person shooters. You use the analogue stick to move your character around, while you use the Wiimote to aim and shoot. The Nunchuck is motion-sensitive too, and also serves as your second punching fist in *Wii Boxing*.

During the first five minutes, we realised that you don't really *need* to stand up or jump around to play on the Wii—flicking your wrist from the comfort of your couch works quite fine. A few minutes later, you wonder whether standing up might actually help, and this is where the trouble begins...

We highly recommend a basic warm-up before hitting the Wii courts / greens / boxing rings, lest you suffer the pain we did.

Are Those...People?

With the hardware that Nintendo had at its disposal, it's surprising that they chose simple, skittle-like models for Wii sports—and surprisingly enough, it's easier to connect with your ridiculously unrealistic in-game avatar (or Mii) than it is when playing any other character! The lack of modelling detail has almost no effect on your game experience; in fact, it adds to the light-heartedness of it all, and will no doubt aid the Wii's Primary Main Objective™—garnering the interest of non-gamers.

Wii Sports features Tennis, Bowling, Baseball, Golf, and Boxing (in order of how much fun they are), and you're explained how to work the controls the first time you play each game.